



SITUATED IN THE NORTH OF EUROPE, Finland shares some unusual features with its neighbors. The

FINNS

OLD TRADITIONS AND NEW INVENTIONS

An independent country

Finland belonged to Sweden from the 12th to the 19th century, and after that to Russia. It became independent in 1917 and successfully resisted invasions from both the Soviet Union and Nazi Germany. In recent times Finland's telecommunications industry has grown rapidly, to the extent that Finns use more mobile phones per person than anyone else in the world.



WOOD IS GOOD

Three-quarters of Finland is forest, providing hunting, fishing, land for grazing animals, and, most importantly, wood. In the past, wood was needed for fuel, furniture, and other everyday items. Today it is used to a lesser extent, but exporting wood is still vital to the Finnish economy.



LIGHTING THE WAY

This family is making a beacon that will help their children to find their way home from school in the dark. During the winter months some days will only have two hours of sunlight.



WINTER SPORTS

Naturally, the climate means that sports like cross-country skiing and snowboarding are popular in Finland, but so is *pesäpallo*, the national sport, which is somewhat like baseball. People also keep in shape by cycling instead of driving cars.

HOLIDAY ON ICE

Ski holiday week, or *hiibtolomaviikko*, takes place around March and always boosts morale. Officially this is a students' holiday, but adults also take the opportunity to go cross-country skiing or snowmobiling. In the evening, people stop for a barbeque supper and set up camp overnight in the forests.



Even very young children are used to playing in the snow with sleds or skis.

